THE MOP FLOOD: WHY THOUSANDS OF HDB OWNERS WILL LOSE BIG

The Hidden Window Most HDB Owners Will Miss
And How It Could Cost You **$100,000+**

DARREN KHEW

A SINGAPORE PROPERTY GUIDE

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FOREWORD

Why I Wrote This And Who It Is For

There is a particular kind of silence that settles over a conversation when someone realises, halfway through our discussion, that they have already missed something important. I have sat with enough HDB owners over the years to recognise that silence instantly. It is not panic. It is not anger. It is something quieter and more unsettling than either of those things. It is the feeling of understanding, too late, that a window was open and is now beginning to close.

I did not write this book to alarm you. I wrote it because I kept having the same conversation, over and over again, with people who were intelligent, hardworking, and genuinely well-intentioned about their finances, but who simply did not have the full picture of what was happening in the property market around them. They were watching the wrong signals. They were asking the wrong questions. And by the time the right questions found them, the answers had become more complicated and more expensive than they needed to be.

I am a real estate agent. I work in Singapore's property market every single day, and what I am going to share with you in the pages that follow is not theory. It is not something I read in a report and decided to package up for you. It is the accumulation of what I have observed, studied, and worked through with the people who have trusted me with one of the most significant financial decisions of their lives. The property market is my profession and my discipline, and I take both seriously.

What prompted me to put all of this into writing is the moment we are in right now. Because right now, in 2026, something is happening in Singapore's HDB resale market that most flat owners are simply not paying enough attention to. Not because they are careless. Not because they do not care about their financial future. But because the signals are easy to miss if you are not specifically looking for them, and because the consequences of missing them tend to arrive slowly at first, then all at once.

> *The HDB Resale Price Index recorded its first quarterly decline in nearly seven years in the first quarter of 2026. The quarter before that was flat, the first flat quarter in five years. The flood is not coming. It has already arrived.*

I want to be clear about what you will find here and what you will not. You will not find manufactured urgency, inflated promises, or predictions dressed up as certainties. The property market is complex, and anyone who tells you they know exactly what prices will do next year is either misinformed or not being straight with you. What you will find instead is a clear, honest, and well-researched account of what is happening in the market right now, why it matters to you specifically as an HDB owner, what your genuine options are, and how to think about making a decision that serves your financial interests and your family's future.

Whether you end up making a move in the next twelve months or deciding that staying put is the right call for your circumstances, I want you to make that choice with full information rather than incomplete information. Because the difference between those two things, in the property market, can easily amount to six figures over the course of four to five years.

If that matters to you, read on.

CHAPTER ONE

The Flood Is Already Here

The Biggest Supply Wave in a Decade Has Quietly Begun

I want to start by telling you something that might feel counterintuitive, especially if you have been following property news in Singapore for any length of time. The most important thing happening in the HDB resale market right now is not price movements. It is not interest rates. It is not the latest round of government policy adjustments, as consequential as those are. The most important thing happening right now is supply. Specifically, the largest wave of HDB flats entering Minimum Occupation Period eligibility that this market has seen in over a decade.

And the reason most owners are not paying sufficient attention to it is precisely because supply is a slow-moving story. It does not make headlines the way a record transaction does. It does not trigger the same emotional response as a dramatic price swing. It builds quietly, steadily, and then one day the market looks fundamentally different from what it looked like twelve months ago, and people start asking what happened.

I can tell you what happened. I am going to walk you through it carefully, because understanding this supply story is the foundation of every other decision you might make about your property in the next few years.

Let me start with the Minimum Occupation Period itself, because I have found that even owners who are approaching their MOP sometimes hold a slightly inaccurate understanding of when exactly it applies. The five-year MOP clock begins from the date of key collection, which is the date you physically received your keys to the flat. It does not begin from the date you submitted your application, from the date of the ballot, or from the date you signed your Sales of Balance Flat agreement. This matters in practice because the gap between application and key collection for a Build-To-Order flat can span several years, and many owners have a rough sense of their MOP date that is slightly off. If you are within eighteen months of your MOP on either side, I would encourage you to verify the exact date from your HDB documentation before making any assumptions about your timeline.

13,480	93%	53,000+	0.1%
HDB units reaching MOP in 2026	Jump in supply from to 2025 2026	Total MOP units 2026 to 2028	RPI decline Q1 2026, first drop since 2019

Now, to the numbers. In 2026, 13,480 HDB flats are completing their five-year Minimum Occupation Period. That figure comes from National Development Ministry completion data and has been confirmed independently by leading property research firms. To put that number in context, only 6,970 HDB flats cleared their MOP in 2025, which was itself the lowest MOP supply figure in over a decade. What you are looking at, from 2025 to 2026, is a 93 percent increase in MOP-eligible supply in a single year. That is not a gradual uptick. That is a near-doubling of the pool of flats that can enter the resale market, concentrated within one calendar year.

And it does not stop there. The figures for 2027 are estimated at approximately 18,939 units. For 2028, approximately 21,393 units. When you add those three years together, more than 53,000 HDB flats are projected to reach MOP eligibility between 2026 and 2028. To appreciate what that means, consider that only around 34,000 flats reached their MOP during the entire three-year period from 2023 to 2025. The volume of supply entering MOP eligibility over the next three years is more than fifty percent larger than it was over the previous three years. That is a structural shift in the market, not a temporary fluctuation.

The reason this supply wave is arriving now is not a mystery. It is the direct result of Singapore's accelerated Build-To-Order construction programme, which ramped up significantly in the years following the COVID-19 pandemic as the government worked to address the construction delays and housing demand that had built up during that period. Those flats were completed, keys were collected, and the five-year MOP clock began ticking. Now, in 2026 and through to 2028, that clock is reaching its conclusion for tens of thousands of households simultaneously.

> *The National Development Minister has stated publicly that resale prices are expected to moderate as the BTO pipeline from the pandemic years reaches MOP. That is not an analyst's opinion. That is government-stated policy intent.*

I raise that point not to suggest the government is working against the interests of HDB owners, because it is not. The moderation of resale prices is a deliberate policy outcome aimed at keeping public housing accessible and affordable across generations. I raise it because when the government signals its expectations for the direction of a market, that signal deserves to be taken seriously by anyone making financial decisions within that market.

The market has already begun responding. The HDB Resale Price Index came in at 203.4 in the first quarter of 2026. That represents a 0.1 percent quarterly decline, the first negative quarter since the second quarter of 2019, a span of nearly seven years during which resale prices had grown without interruption. The quarter before that, in Q4 of 2025, saw zero price growth, the first flat quarter in five years. Two consecutive quarters of zero or negative movement, after years of unbroken growth, is how a trend change typically announces itself. Not with a dramatic crash, but with a quiet stalling that most people explain away until it becomes undeniable.

To put 2026's early performance in perspective: full-year price growth in 2025 came in at approximately three percent, already significantly lower than the 9.7 percent recorded in 2024. And 2024's figure was itself a deceleration from the eight to ten percent growth rates seen during the peak years of the pandemic property surge. The direction of travel is clear, and the supply wave that is building through 2027 and 2028 gives that direction of travel considerable momentum.

I want to be precise about where the MOP wave is hitting hardest in geographic terms, because the impact is not evenly distributed across Singapore's estates. Punggol accounts for the largest share of 2026 MOP units at 3,222 flats. Queenstown follows with 2,409. Tampines contributes 2,133. Toa Payoh and Bidadari together account for approximately 1,594. In areas like Punggol, where a significant portion of recent BTO development was concentrated, the local supply effect will be pronounced.

I want to address something directly here, because it comes up in almost every conversation I have with HDB owners who are beginning to think about this. The question is always some version of: 'But prices have not collapsed. The market still seems okay. Why should I be concerned now?' And it is a fair question. The market has not collapsed. Prices at the headline level are still positive on an annual basis, and premium units in well-located estates are still transacting at record figures. A five-room flat in Dawson Road sold for S$1.7 million in February 2026. Quarterly million-dollar transactions hit a record 412 units in Q1 2026. These headlines are real.

But here is what those headlines do not tell you. The premium segment of the HDB market is a narrow slice of total transactions, concentrated in a small number of estates and flat types that have very specific characteristics. The vast majority of MOP-eligible flats entering the market over the next three years do not share those characteristics. They are not positioned to benefit from the same premium demand dynamics. For those flats, and for the owners who hold them, the headline numbers at the top of the market are not the relevant benchmark.

One final point for this opening chapter: the natural human response to a slowly building situation is to wait for more information before acting. In a supply-driven market, that instinct is the most costly one you can indulge. Supply waves do not reverse quickly. Once 53,000 units have entered MOP eligibility across a three-year window, that inventory is in the market. It does not disappear because a quarter passes without a dramatic price headline. The question is only when each individual owner decides to engage with what is happening. The pages that follow are designed to help you understand exactly what that difference looks like.

CHAPTER TWO

What The Flood Actually Does To Your Flat's Value

How Supply Shifts Buyer Behaviour, Negotiating Power, and Your Net Proceeds

Most people, when they think about property market risk, think about it in one dimension. Prices go up or prices go down. That is the frame through which the majority of HDB owners assess their situation, and it is an understandable one because price is the number that appears most frequently in news articles, in conversations with neighbours, and in the notifications that property portal apps send to your phone. Price is visible. Price is concrete. Price feels like the thing that matters most.

What I want to do in this chapter is expand that frame considerably, because in a supply-driven market environment of the kind Singapore is currently moving through, price is only the beginning of the story. The more complete and more important story involves buyer behaviour, negotiating dynamics, time on market, and the downstream financial consequences that flow from each of those things. When you understand not just that supply affects prices, but how supply affects the entire experience and outcome of selling and buying within the same market cycle, the picture becomes both clearer and more urgent.

Let me start with something that many HDB owners remember vividly from the past few years, because it defined the market they were watching and the expectations they formed during that period. During the peak years of the recent property surge, Cash Over Valuation was a standard feature of HDB resale transactions. For those who are less familiar with the term, Cash Over Valuation refers to the amount a buyer pays above HDB's official valuation of a flat, in cash, on top of the purchase price. This is money that cannot come from CPF savings or a housing loan. It must be paid in physical cash. During the period from roughly 2021 to 2024, Cash Over Valuation figures of $20,000 to $50,000 were not unusual in competitive estates.

Buyers were willing to pay it because supply was tight, competition was fierce, and the fear of losing a flat they wanted to a faster-moving buyer outweighed the pain of parting with that cash. That dynamic is what a sellers' market looks and feels like in practice. Sellers hold the leverage. Buyers compete. Transactions happen quickly. The seller's asking price is the floor of the negotiation, not the ceiling.

> *When a buyer who was previously competing against three or four other interested parties for a flat now has six or eight comparable options to consider, their urgency diminishes. The Cash Over Valuation expectation does not just shrink. It disappears entirely.*

What happens to that dynamic when 13,480 newly MOP-eligible flats enter the resale pool in a single year, followed by approximately 18,939 the year after, and approximately 21,393 the year after that? The answer is not complicated, but its implications are far-reaching. Buyers gain choices. When a buyer who was previously competing against three or four other interested parties for a flat now has six or eight comparable options to consider, their urgency diminishes. They take more time. They submit lower offers. They walk away from negotiations that would have concluded quickly twelve months earlier and come back two weeks later with a revised position that is less favourable to the seller. The Cash Over Valuation expectation does not just shrink. It disappears entirely.

The Q1 2026 data already reflects the early stages of this shift. Resale transaction volumes were 4.5 percent lower year-on-year in the first quarter of 2026 compared to the same period in 2025. Fewer transactions at the aggregate level, combined with the first quarterly price decline in nearly seven years, tells you that the balance of power in negotiating rooms across Singapore has quietly but meaningfully shifted. Buyers are in less of a hurry than they were. Sellers are in more of one, because every week a flat sits on the market unsold is a week that more competing inventory enters the pool around it.

I want to be careful here not to overstate what the data is saying, because intellectual honesty is more useful to you than dramatic framing. The HDB resale market is not in freefall. Premium units in well-located estates continue to attract strong demand. In Q1 2026, 412 HDB flats transacted above S$1 million, a record for a single quarter. But the premium segment represents approximately six percent of all HDB resale transactions. The other 94 percent of the market is operating under different conditions, and it is within those conditions that the majority of MOP-eligible flats entering the pool over the next three years will find themselves competing.

Now I want to walk you through something that I think is genuinely the most important part of this entire book, and it is the mechanics of how the six-figure number in the title becomes real. Because that number is not invented. It is not a marketing claim dressed up in bold type. It is the compounded result of three separate financial effects that work together in ways most HDB owners have not been shown clearly.

The first effect is the most obvious one. A seller who enters the market later in the supply wave, when competition among sellers has increased significantly and buyer leverage has grown, will typically achieve a lower sale price than they would have achieved entering the same market twelve to eighteen months earlier. Even a seemingly modest difference in achieved sale price of $30,000 to $50,000 is not an abstract financial concept. It is real money that flows directly into the next part of the equation.

The second effect is where the compounding begins, and it is the one that catches most owners off guard. When an HDB flat is sold, the proceeds do not all flow freely into the owner's hands. CPF funds that were used to service the mortgage, including both the principal and the accrued interest that CPF charges on withdrawn amounts, must be refunded back to the CPF Ordinary Account before the remainder can be accessed as cash. What this means in practice is that a lower sale price does not just reduce your gross proceeds by the difference in price. It reduces your net cash position after the CPF refund by the same amount, which is the figure that actually matters when you are calculating what you have available for your next property's downpayment.

The third effect operates over the longest time horizon and is therefore the easiest to underestimate, but it is in many ways the most financially significant of the three. When you purchase your next property, the size of your downpayment determines your Loan-to-Value ratio. A stronger downpayment position gives you a lower Loan-to-Value ratio, which in turn gives you access to more competitive mortgage packages. A weaker downpayment position pushes you into a higher Loan-to-Value ratio and potentially into a less favourable mortgage rate tier. The difference between a mortgage rate of 1.7 percent and one of 2.1 percent on a loan of

S$800,000 over a 25-year term accumulates to a significant sum across the life of that loan.

> *When you stack these three effects together, the path to a six-figure financial difference over a four to five year window is not only plausible. It is, for a meaningful number of owners who delay past the supply peak, the likely outcome.*

If you are planning to sell your HDB flat and use the proceeds to purchase a private property, your exposure to the current market environment is doubled. You are simultaneously a seller in a market that is becoming more competitive and a buyer in a private property market that has remained more resilient. New private condo launches in the Outside Central Region, which is where most HDB upgraders are looking, are currently priced at between S$1.6 million and S$2.1 million across approximately 65 percent of available stock.

What this means practically is that the negotiating environment on your sell side is softening while your buy side remains firm. Every dollar you fail to maximise on the HDB sale is a dollar you must find elsewhere to fund a private purchase that has not softened proportionally. This is the asymmetry that most directly explains how the numbers in this book's title become real for individual households.

What the data tells me, as someone who works in this market every day, is that the environment for HDB sellers is measurably different today from what it was in 2024, and it is likely to become more different still as we move through 2027 and into 2028. The supply wave that is driving these changes is not a short-term event. It is a three-year structural shift that will play out in full regardless of what else happens around it.

CHAPTER THREE

The Hidden Window

Why Timing Is The Entire Game

There is a concept in property that experienced investors understand intuitively but that most ordinary homeowners never get the chance to encounter until it is relevant to their own situation. It is the idea of a market window. Not a window in the sense of a brief, arbitrary opening that appears and disappears randomly. A market window in the sense of a specific period within a larger market cycle where conditions align in a way that creates a meaningfully better outcome for those who act within it, compared to those who act before it or after it. These windows are real. They are measurable in hindsight. And the frustrating truth about them is that they are rarely obvious while they are open. They become obvious only after they have closed.

I believe there is a window open in Singapore's HDB resale market right now. I also believe it is already narrowing. And I want to use this chapter to explain exactly why I think that, with enough precision and honesty that you can assess the argument for yourself rather than simply taking my word for it.

Let me begin with the current state of the market, stated in the clearest possible terms. The HDB Resale Price Index stood at 203.4 at the end of Q1 2026, reflecting a 0.1 percent quarterly decline. That is the first negative quarter since Q2 2019. The quarter before it, Q4 2025, recorded zero growth, the first flat quarter in five years. Five consecutive quarters of slower or stagnant growth, culminating in the first outright quarterly decline in nearly seven years, is not a market that is pausing temporarily before resuming its previous momentum. It is a market that is undergoing a structural transition.

> *Market windows never send an unambiguous signal while they are open. They only look obvious in hindsight, at which point the observation is interesting but no longer useful.*

Full-year price growth in 2025 came in at approximately three percent, a sharp deceleration from the 9.7 percent recorded in 2024. The trajectory from double-digit growth in the early part of the decade, to high single digits, to low single digits, to flat, to the first quarterly decline, is not accidental. It is the predictable result of a significant and sustained increase in housing supply intersecting with a market where buyer affordability has natural limits and where government cooling measures have been deliberately calibrated to moderate speculative demand.

I find it useful, when thinking about what happens next, to map the current moment against a simple three-phase framework that describes how supply-driven market transitions typically unfold. I am not presenting this as an academic model. I am presenting it as a way of organising what the data is already showing us into a form that makes the timing question easier to think about clearly.

The first phase is what I call the early window. This is the period when supply is rising but has not yet reached its peak, when the market is adjusting to new inventory but the adjustment has not yet fully worked its way through buyer behaviour and pricing expectations. In the early window, sellers who are MOP-eligible and prepared to act still carry meaningful negotiating leverage. For a seller who enters the market in this phase, the conditions are more favourable than what is coming, even if they are less spectacular than what has passed.

The second phase is the mid-flood period. This is when the supply wave is at or near its peak, when 18,000 to 21,000 MOP-eligible units are entering the resale pool annually and competing simultaneously for the same base of active buyers. Cash Over Valuation is gone from the majority of the market. Time on market lengthens noticeably. Sellers who need to transact within a defined timeline find their negotiating position significantly weaker than they anticipated, often because they formed their price expectations during the previous phase or earlier.

The third phase is the saturation point, the period when cumulative supply has outpaced the market's absorption capacity and the effects on pricing and transaction conditions become most pronounced. What I can say with confidence is that the trajectory from the first phase to the second is already well underway, as the Q4 2025 and Q1 2026 data confirm.

My reading of the available data is that we are in the late stages of the early window, transitioning into the beginning of the mid-flood phase. The first quarterly price decline in seven years is the clearest signal that the early window is not fully open in the way it was twelve months ago. But the supply peak, which will arrive as the 2027 and 2028 cohorts of MOP units enter the market, has not yet arrived. The conditions for a seller who acts now, while not as favourable as they were in 2024, are still materially better than the conditions that are likely to characterise the market at the height of the supply wave.

That is the window. It is not a wide window. It is not a window that will stay open indefinitely while you gather more information and weigh your options at a comfortable pace. It is a window that the data suggests is already in the process of narrowing, and that will narrow further and more rapidly as the months pass and the cumulative weight of new MOP supply makes itself felt across the estates where the bulk of that supply is concentrated.

I want to spend some time on the question of why intelligent, financially literate people consistently underestimate market windows of this kind, because I do not think the failure to act within them is ever really about a lack of information at its core. It is almost always about the nature of how human beings respond to slowly developing situations. We are wired to respond to sudden, dramatic changes in our environment. A slow, steady shift in market dynamics that unfolds over several quarters tends to be rationalised away at each individual data point, because no single data point looks alarming enough on its own to override the inertia of staying put.

Q4 2025 recorded flat price growth. That was easy to explain away as a seasonal softening. Q1 2026 recorded the first quarterly decline in seven years. That is harder to explain away, but the 0.1 percent figure is small enough in absolute terms that the temptation to dismiss it as a rounding error is understandable. By the time the data is unambiguous enough that the average observer feels the urgency that the situation warrants, the opportunity to act within the favourable window will have significantly diminished.

The government's own signalling on this point deserves more attention than it typically receives. The National Development Minister has stated publicly that resale prices are expected to moderate in the years ahead as the BTO flats from the pandemic period reach their MOP. That statement was made not in a research report and not by a private analyst with a position to promote. It was made by the minister responsible for housing policy, which means it reflects both an expectation of what the market will do and an indication of the policy intent that the government is prepared to allow that moderation to occur.

I also want to address the role of external economic factors. The supply wave of 53,000 plus MOP-eligible units across 2026 to 2028 will materialise regardless of what external economic factors do. Those flats have been built, keys have been collected, and the five-year clocks are running. The supply is coming on a schedule set by completion dates and key collection dates, not by macroeconomic variables. The bear case for HDB sellers waiting for external conditions to improve is therefore not simply that conditions might not improve. It is that a deterioration in external conditions would make an already supply-pressured market worse, not better.

There is something else I want to say here that I think is genuinely important, and it is about the nature of the decision that this window presents. Acting within the current window does not mean making a rushed decision. What it means is beginning the process of getting clarity now, rather than in six months or a year, so that if and when you decide to act, you are in a position to do so from preparation rather than from urgency. The owners who will look back on this period most positively are not necessarily the ones who moved the fastest. They are the ones who started thinking clearly about their situation earliest.

CHAPTER FOUR

Your Options On The Table

A Clear, Honest Look at Every Path Available to You Right Now

One of the things I have noticed consistently over the years of working with HDB owners through periods of market change is that the conversation almost always starts from the same place. People want to know what they should do. They want a clear, singular answer that they can take away and act on with confidence. And I understand that impulse completely, because the property market involves large sums of money, significant life decisions, and a level of complexity that most people do not navigate regularly enough to feel instinctively comfortable with.

The honest truth, however, is that there is no single answer that applies to every HDB owner reading this book. What there is instead is a set of genuinely distinct options, each with its own financial mechanics, its own eligibility requirements, its own risks and advantages, and its own fit with different personal circumstances. What I want to do in this chapter is lay every one of those options out in full, with enough clarity and honesty that you can assess which of them is most relevant to your situation. I am not going to steer you toward any particular path. My job in these pages is to make sure you understand the full landscape before you decide which direction to walk in.

Before I go through the options themselves, there is a foundational piece of context that I need to establish clearly, because it affects which options are available to you and what those options look like in practice. In 2024, Singapore's HDB replaced its longstanding classification of flats into mature and non-mature estates with a new three-tier system that divides all HDB flats into Standard, Plus, and Prime categories. This change is not cosmetic. It carries materially different rules for each category, and failing to understand which category your flat falls into before making any property decision is a significant oversight.

Standard flats carry a five-year MOP. Plus flats require a ten-year MOP and cannot be rented out in full even after MOP. Prime flats carry the same ten-year MOP, a full rental prohibition, and a higher subsidy recovery rate on sale. Which tier your flat belongs to changes everything about what your options are.

Standard flats are the most common category and carry the rules that most existing HDB owners will be familiar with. The Minimum Occupation Period is five years from the date of key collection, after which the flat can be sold on the open resale market or rented out in its entirety, subject to HDB's standard subletting eligibility requirements. Plus flats carry a ten-year MOP, and Plus flat owners are not permitted to rent out their entire unit at any point, even after the MOP has been completed. Room rental remains available under specific HDB-approved conditions, but whole-unit subletting is permanently off the table. Prime flats carry a ten-year MOP, the same full rental prohibition, and the highest subsidy clawback rate on sale.

Option One: Sell and Upgrade to Private Property

The first option, and the one that is most frequently on the minds of owners who come to me during the MOP period, is selling the flat and upgrading to private property. For Standard flat owners who have completed their five-year MOP, this is a genuinely viable and in many cases financially compelling path. Singapore Citizens purchasing their first private residential property pay zero Additional Buyer's Stamp Duty. Bank loans for private property carry a Loan-to-Value limit of up to 75 percent. And fixed mortgage rates currently sit between 1.55 and 2.40 percent, representing a meaningful improvement in borrowing costs compared to the peak of the rate cycle.

The mechanics of the upgrade transaction contain a critical decision point that I want to explain with considerable care, because getting this wrong is one of the most common and financially damaging mistakes I see upgraders make. The decision is the sequencing of the transaction: whether you sell your HDB flat before purchasing the private property, or whether you purchase the private property first and sell the HDB flat afterward.

If you sell the HDB flat first and then purchase a private property as a Singapore Citizen with no other residential property to your name at the point of purchase, you pay zero Additional Buyer's Stamp Duty on the private property. This is the cleanest and most financially straightforward path. The practical challenge it presents is that you need somewhere to live between the completion of the HDB sale and the completion of the private property purchase.

> *On a $1.5 million condo, buying before selling your HDB means $300,000 in Additional Buyer's Stamp Duty paid upfront in cash. The difference between a well-sequenced and a poorly-sequenced upgrade transaction can amount to six figures in unnecessary costs.*

If you purchase the private property before selling your HDB flat, you are required to pay Additional Buyer's Stamp Duty at the rate of 20 percent of the purchase price or market value, whichever is higher, within 14 days of signing the Sale and Purchase Agreement. On a private property priced at S$1.5 million, that is S$300,000 in stamp duty, payable in cash or from your CPF account, before you have received a single dollar from the sale of your HDB flat. There is a remission mechanism available, which allows you to claim back that Additional Buyer's Stamp Duty payment if you sell your HDB flat within six months of purchasing the private property. But this remission is not automatic.

Option Two: Sell and Right-Size

Right-sizing refers to the decision to sell the current flat and move into a smaller or differently configured property that better suits the owner's current life circumstances, releasing equity in the process rather than reinvesting all of it into a larger or more expensive property. The owners for whom right-sizing tends to be most relevant include those whose children have grown and moved out, owners who are approaching retirement and want to convert a portion of their property equity into liquid assets, and owners who have specific financial goals for whom unlocking property equity at the right moment in the market cycle is a meaningful strategic move.

Option Three: Hold and Do Nothing

Holding can be the right decision. But it needs to be a deliberate choice made with full knowledge of what the market environment is likely to mean for the flat's value trajectory, not a default position that happens by inaction. Full-year price growth in 2025 came in at approximately three percent. The first quarter of 2026 recorded the first quarterly price decline in nearly seven years. The supply wave building through 2027 and 2028 gives no indication of reversing. For holding to be the optimal financial choice from this point forward, prices would need to recover meaningfully before the supply peak, the owner's flat would need to outperform the broader market conditions, and the upgrade opportunity the owner is deferring would need to remain equally available and equally financially attractive in twelve to twenty-four months.

Option Four: Rent Out and Generate Income

For Standard flat owners who have completed their Minimum Occupation Period and who meet HDB's subletting eligibility criteria, whole-unit rental is an option worth understanding properly. Singapore's rental market has remained relatively resilient even as resale prices have moderated. I want to be direct about the limitations: Plus and Prime flat owners cannot rent out their entire unit at any point, regardless of whether the MOP has been completed. This is a permanent restriction tied to the flat classification, not a temporary one tied to the MOP timeline. Room rental within Plus and Prime flats remains possible under specific HDB-approved conditions.

Option Five: Ownership Restructuring and the Essential Occupier Strategy

HDB does not permit co-owners to decouple a jointly owned flat for investment or financial planning purposes. HDB permits ownership transfers between HDB co-owners only in three specific circumstances: divorce, the death of a co-owner, and cases of genuine financial hardship. Attempting to restructure HDB ownership outside of these circumstances is not a strategy that is available, and any advice suggesting otherwise should be treated with significant scepticism.

However, there is a related strategy that is entirely legitimate and that every married couple who has not yet applied for their BTO flat should understand before they submit their application. It is called the essential occupier arrangement. When a couple applies for a BTO flat, one spouse can be listed as the essential occupier rather than as a co-owner. The essential occupier lives in the flat and is part of the family nucleus that qualifies the application, but they are not a named owner of the property. Once the MOP is completed, the essential occupier can purchase a private property in their own name, paying zero Additional Buyer's Stamp Duty as a Singapore Citizen purchasing their first residential property, while the HDB flat remains owned solely by the other spouse. This arrangement must be set up at the point of the original application. It cannot be created retrospectively after the flat has been purchased with both parties as co-owners.

There is one thing I want to say to close this chapter that runs across all five options I have described. The property decisions that most people look back on with the greatest satisfaction are not necessarily the ones that produced the highest returns in a mathematical sense. They are the ones that were made with full information, that were aligned with the family's genuine needs and goals at the time, and that were executed with proper planning rather than reactive urgency.

CHAPTER FIVE

The Implementation Window

Knowledge Without Action Is Just Entertainment

I have a confession to make, and I think it is an appropriate one to open the final chapter of this book with. Over the years, I have had conversations with HDB owners that ended with them saying something along the lines of: 'Thank you, this has been really helpful, I have a much clearer picture now.' And then I never heard from them again. Not because the conversation was not useful. Not because they did not genuinely mean what they said. But because the gap between understanding something clearly and doing something about it is wider than most people anticipate, and it is a gap that the demands of everyday life are very effective at filling with other priorities.

I am not saying this to be unkind about human nature, because I think the tendency is entirely understandable. Property decisions are large, complex, and emotionally significant. They involve your home, your family, your financial security, and a level of commitment that most people do not enter into lightly. The instinct to think carefully before acting is not a flaw. It is a virtue. The problem arises when thinking carefully becomes a substitute for acting rather than a preparation for it, and when the window within which acting would have produced the best outcome closes quietly while the thinking is still ongoing.

> *The biggest barrier for most owners is not a lack of willingness to engage. It is a lack of clarity about what engaging actually looks like in practical terms.*

What I want to do in this final chapter is make the path from awareness to action as clear and as concrete as I possibly can, because I think the biggest barrier for most owners is not a lack of willingness to engage. It is a lack of clarity about what engaging actually looks like in practical terms. What is the first step? What do you need to know before you can take it? What does a genuine assessment of your situation involve? These are the questions I want to answer here, as directly as I can.

Let me start with three foundational questions that every HDB owner should be able to answer with specific, verified numbers before they make any property decision of significance. Not approximate answers based on what you think you remember from when you bought the flat. Not estimates based on what you have seen on property portals recently. Specific, verified numbers that come from your actual documents, your CPF account, and a proper assessment of your current property's market position.

The first question is whether your flat has completed its Minimum Occupation Period, or if not, exactly when it will. The MOP clock begins from the date of key collection, and the specific date matters more than the approximate year. If you are six months away from your MOP, your decision timeline looks very different from someone who crossed their MOP two years ago and has been sitting on eligibility without acting on it. Pull out your HDB documentation, find the key collection date, add exactly five years to it if you own a Standard flat or ten years if you own a Plus or Prime flat, and write that date down somewhere you will not forget it. Everything else flows from that date.

The second question is what your net equity position looks like after accounting for your CPF refund obligation. This is the number that most owners significantly overestimate when they first start thinking about an upgrade, because the headline sale price of their flat sounds like the money they will have available, and the CPF refund obligation feels abstract until someone puts a specific figure on it. Your CPF refund obligation includes all the CPF funds you have withdrawn for the flat's purchase and ongoing mortgage payments, plus the accrued interest that the CPF Board charges on those withdrawals at the current CPF Ordinary Account interest rate. This interest compounds over time, which means that for owners who have been servicing their mortgage with CPF contributions over five or more years, the refund obligation can be substantially larger than they expect.

The third question is what your current income and total debt position looks like relative to the financing requirements of the property you are considering moving into. Singapore's Total Debt Servicing Ratio framework caps the proportion of a borrower's gross monthly income that can be committed to all debt obligations, including the proposed new mortgage, at 55 percent. This is a hard regulatory ceiling that lenders apply to every loan application, and it determines the maximum loan quantum you can qualify for regardless of how strong your property equity position is.

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Numbers every owner must verify before any decision	TDSR ceiling — hard on limit all loan obligations	ABSD for SCs buying their first private property	Window to sell HDB for after buying private ABSD remission

Once you have clear, verified answers to those three questions, you are in a position to have a genuinely productive conversation with a property advisor and, separately, with a mortgage specialist. I say separately and deliberately, because these are two distinct conversations that serve different purposes and that benefit from being approached as such. The property conversation is about understanding your current flat's market position, what the realistic sale outcome looks like in the current supply environment, and which of the five options I outlined in the previous chapter is most aligned with your circumstances and goals. The mortgage conversation is about understanding your borrowing capacity precisely, what the most competitive financing options currently look like, and how the specific numbers of your intended next property fit within the financing framework available to you.

I want to say something about what a genuine property review looks like, as opposed to what a transaction-motivated conversation looks like, because the difference matters and I think owners deserve to be able to tell them apart. A genuine property review begins with your situation, not with a property. It starts by establishing your CPF position, your outstanding loan balance if you are still carrying one, your net equity calculation, and your upgrade affordability before a single specific property is mentioned. It involves an honest assessment of your flat's current market value based on recent comparable transactions in your specific estate, not on the highest price achieved in a neighbouring estate by a flat with different characteristics. And it walks through your options with equal treatment given to all of them, including the option of doing nothing.

If a conversation begins with a specific property recommendation before your financial position has been properly assessed, that is a signal worth paying attention to. If the numbers being presented to you are built on optimistic assumptions about sale price that are not grounded in current comparable transactions, that is another signal. You are entitled to ask where every number comes from and to receive a clear, evidenced answer. A competent and honest advisor will welcome those questions, because their value to you depends on your trust in what they are telling you, and that trust can only be built on transparency.

I also want to speak to the role that timing plays in the implementation process itself. Acting within the window does not require you to list your flat for sale tomorrow. It does not require you to sign anything or commit to anything before you are ready. What it requires is that you begin the process of understanding your position clearly enough to make an informed decision while there is still enough of the window remaining to act on that decision from a position of preparation rather than urgency. The owners who end up in the most difficult situations are not typically those who acted too soon. They are those who started the process too late, who found themselves trying to make complex financial decisions under time pressure, and who made choices that they would not have made if they had given themselves more runway.

> *HDB has publicly advised households to exercise prudence given the uncertain macroeconomic outlook. I am not suggesting you ignore it. But macroeconomic uncertainty is not a reason to avoid making property decisions indefinitely. It is a reason to make them carefully.*

I want to address something that I know is at the back of the mind of many owners reading this, and that is the question of the macroeconomic environment. HDB itself, in its Q1 2026 communications, advised households to exercise prudence in property decisions given the uncertain macroeconomic outlook. I think that is sound and responsible advice. The global economic environment in 2026 carries genuine uncertainties, and any financial commitment as significant as a property transaction should be made with a clear-eyed assessment of your household's resilience under a range of economic scenarios, not just under the most optimistic one. Can you service the mortgage on your intended next property if your income were to reduce temporarily? Do you have sufficient liquid reserves to cover unexpected costs during a transition period? These are not questions designed to discourage you. They are questions that a responsible advisor will walk through with you as part of any serious review.

What I would also say, in the same spirit of honesty, is that macroeconomic uncertainty is not a reason to avoid making property decisions indefinitely. It is a reason to make them carefully, with proper financial preparation and realistic assumptions. The supply story I have described in this book is not dependent on the macroeconomic environment resolving in any particular direction. The 53,000 plus MOP-eligible units entering the market from 2026 to 2028 will arrive regardless of what global trade conditions or interest rate trajectories look like.

I want to close this book the way I opened it, with honesty rather than theatre. I did not write these pages to persuade you to make a transaction. I wrote them because I believe that the information asymmetry in the property market is genuinely costly to the people on the wrong side of it. Not because anyone is deliberately withholding information, but because property market dynamics are complex, the signals are often slow-moving and easy to misread, and most owners simply do not have the time or the professional context to stay across all of it while also living their lives.

What I hope this book has done is close some of that gap for you. The MOP supply wave of 2026 to 2028 is real, it is large, and its effects on the HDB resale market are already visible in the Q4 2025 and Q1 2026 price data. The window that exists for owners who want to act before the full weight of that supply makes itself felt is real, and it is narrowing. Your options are genuine, they are varied, and the right one for you depends on your specific circumstances rather than on a general prescription that applies to everyone.

Your MOP Date. Your Net Equity After CPF Refund. Your Borrowing Capacity Under TDSR. Those three numbers are where your property future begins.

The flood is here. The window is open. What you do next is entirely up to you. But I hope that after reading this book, whatever you decide, you make that decision with the full picture in front of you rather than a partial one. That, more than anything else, is what I set out to give you when I sat down to write these pages.

And if you want to talk through what those numbers look like for your specific situation, you know where to find me.

"*Knowledge is powerful.*
The implementation is where the money is made."

Darren Khew